Unnoticed Disclosure: Readers Do Not Register AI Source Labels on De-Influencing Content

Abstract—Platforms are moving toward mandatory labelling of AI-generated content, on the assumption that disclosure changes how a reader receives a message. We tested that assumption for de-influencing content, where creators advise audiences against a purchase. In a between-subjects experiment, 183 participants read an identical de-influencing post attributed either to a human creator or to an AI tool, then reported their perceptions of it, their trust in it, and what they would be likely to do. A manipulation check placed immediately after the post found that 50.8% could name the attributed source, a rate indistinguishable from chance (binomial p = .883, 95% CI [.433, .583]). Consumer trust did not differ between conditions in the full sample (t(132.8) = −0.56, p = .577, d = −0.09). Among the 93 participants who did register the label, the difference favoured the AI condition (t(87.1) = −1.82, p = .072, d = −0.37). Random Forest modelling placed attributed source last of twelve predictors of trust, with an importance of .004, while message persuasiveness, AI literacy and perceived authenticity dominated. Regression predicted trust with a cross-validated R^2 of .578 and classification predicted anti-consumption behavior with a cross-validated AUC of .879. In this setting, disclosure labelling seems to fail at the point of perception, before readers get as far as evaluating the source: most did not register the label at all.

Keywords—AI disclosure, de-influencing, consumer trust, anti-consumption, source attribution, machine learning

I. Introduction

Influencer marketing rests on trust. A follower who sees a product recommendation cannot test the claim before acting on it, so they are mostly judging the person who makes it [1]. De-influencing turns this arrangement around. Here creators tell their audience what not to buy, arguing that some trending item is overpriced, does not work as advertised, or is simply unnecessary, and researchers have connected the practice to authenticity, moral responsibility and consumer anti-consumption behavior [2], [3].

Generative AI has made writing of this kind cheap to produce in quantity, and readers are poor at recognising it. In six experiments asking people to judge whether short texts were written by a person or generated by a model, accuracy stayed close to chance [4]. Platforms have nonetheless begun requiring AI disclosure labels, working from the assumption that telling readers a message came from a machine will change how they receive it.

For de-influencing content that assumption has not been tested. Studies of de-influencing have looked at human creators [2], [3], [5]. Studies of AI-generated content have concentrated on advertising and virtual influencers [6]–[8], where the message is selling something rather than arguing against it. The difference may matter, because part of what makes a de-influencing message persuasive is that the creator seems to be giving something up, forgoing revenue in order to warn an audience. It is unclear whether a reader would credit an AI system with giving anything up.

There is a methodological problem as well. Most existing work is observational or based on what participants recall seeing, which means the message and its source vary together. When both change at once, the effect of who wrote something cannot be told apart from the effect of what was written.

We designed this study to pull the two apart. Participants read a single de-influencing post whose wording never changed, while the label above it attributed the post either to a human creator or to an AI tool. A manipulation check placed immediately afterwards asked them to identify the source they had just been shown.

That check produced the study's central result. Only half the participants could say who had written the post they had finished reading moments earlier, a rate no better than guessing. The label sat where such labels ordinarily sit, directly above the content, in the position platforms use for disclosure notices, and almost nobody read it. Whatever effect AI attribution may have on trust, it cannot work through a cue that readers never take in. We therefore report the perception failure as the primary finding, and treat the attribution question as secondary, answerable only within the subgroup that registered the label.

The paper makes three contributions. It measures directly whether source disclosure in its standard position is perceived, which disclosure research has usually assumed without testing. It reports the attribution effect within the subgroup that did perceive the label, where the difference runs against the intuitive prediction. And it ranks the determinants of consumer trust in de-influencing content using machine learning, finding that attributed source contributes almost nothing beside the perceived qualities of the message itself.

Section II covers related work and sets out the hypotheses. Section III describes the design, the instrument and the analysis. Section IV reports results, Section V discusses what they imply, and Section VI closes with limitations and directions for further work.

II. Related Work

A. Influencer Trust and De-Influencing

Trust does a lot of work in influencer marketing because there is usually no way for a follower to check what they are being told. Lou and Yuan found that the value of an influencer's content and their perceived credibility both shape how far followers trust branded posts [1]. The question of what makes a source credible is considerably older than social media. Ohanian settled on expertise and trustworthiness as the dimensions audiences judge endorsers by, and the scale built around them is still what most researchers use [10].

De-influencing runs the other way. The creator advises against a purchase rather than recommending one, and the message is assembled from reasons not to buy [2]. In form it is a species of negative electronic word of mouth, where consumer-generated evaluations have long been shown to shape purchase decisions at scale [11], but here the speaker has an audience to lose. Michaelidou et al. found that content of this sort can lead consumers to reconsider purchases and choose more responsibly [3]. Giving up the obvious commercial motive puts authenticity at the centre of whether

the message works, though it does not remove suspicion altogether, since audiences can still imagine a hidden interest such as a rival sponsorship. Harff and Le tested this in a pre-registered between-subjects experiment and found that a negative influencer review was judged considerably more helpful than a positive one even though brand image and purchase intentions did not shift [5]. An experimental design of this kind can leave the headline outcome unmoved while still showing an effect on how the communicator is judged.

B. AI-Generated Content and Source Attribution

Where consumers have been asked about AI-generated marketing material, they tend to be cautious when its authenticity and transparency are unclear [6]. The same shows up in work on AI-generated short-form video, where emotional authenticity and transparency affect trust and engagement [7], and in research on virtual influencers [8], though in every case the content being studied is selling something.

Detection is the first issue. Jakesch, Hancock and Naaman ran six experiments asking people to judge whether short self-presentations had been written by a person or produced by a model, and accuracy hovered near chance in every setting they tested [4]. Their errors were systematic, following consistent but wrong intuitions about what AI writing looks like. For a study like this one, that leaves the label as the only information about provenance a reader has.

The effect of the label is also hard to predict. Jakesch et al. looked at whether Airbnb hosts came across as less trustworthy when their profile text was believed to be AI-written [9]. Trust did fall, but only among participants who thought they were seeing a mixture of AI- and human-written profiles. When every profile carried the AI label, nothing happened to trust. The authors named this the Replicant Effect and suggested that suspicion needs something to compare against. Because each participant in the present study sees only one condition, this is a good reason not to assume from the outset that AI attribution will reduce trust.

Research on source labelling rarely asks a prior question. Studies manipulate attribution and measure the response, which presumes the manipulation reaches the participant. In a laboratory, where the label is the salient feature of an otherwise sparse stimulus, that presumption is usually safe. It is less obviously safe on a social feed, where a label competes with the content beneath it and readers move quickly. Since detection from the text alone runs at chance [4], a label that goes unread leaves the reader with no information about provenance at all. Whether such labels are perceived under realistic reading conditions has not, so far as we can tell, been measured directly.

C. Consumer Skepticism and AI Literacy

How readily someone doubts a persuasive claim varies from person to person. Obermiller and Spangenberg treated skepticism toward advertising as a general disposition to disbelieve advertising claims and developed a validated scale for it [12], and since de-influencing is still persuasion there is little reason to think the disposition stops operating here. AI literacy adds a second source of variation, in that consumers who understand what AI tools can do may judge AI-attributed content differently [6], [7]. The near-chance detection rates in [4] suggest this is an ability people claim more readily than they hold it, which is a reason to measure it directly.

D. Research Gap and Hypotheses

These literatures have grown up alongside each other without meeting. AI-generated de-influencing content is barely examined. The work on AI source labelling has taken place outside consumer settings [4], [9], and the work on de-influencing has never held the message constant while varying who is said to have written it [2], [3]. The hypotheses below follow from this gap.

TABLE I. HYPOTHESES

	Hypothesis
H1	A majority of participants will correctly identify the attributed source of the post immediately after reading it.
H2	Consumer trust differs between content attributed to a human creator and identical content attributed to an AI tool. Given the Replicant Effect [9], no direction is predicted.
H3	Perceived authenticity, expertise, transparency, message persuasiveness and source credibility are positively associated with consumer trust.
H4	Higher consumer trust is associated with a greater likelihood of reported anti-consumption behavior.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Design and Participants

We used a between-subjects experimental design, administered as an anonymous online questionnaire. Participants read a single de-influencing post and were told that either a human creator had written it or an AI tool had generated it. The post itself was worded identically in both cases. We did not show both versions to the same person, since anyone who saw the two labels together would have guessed what was being tested and answered accordingly.

Participants were recruited through broad online distribution of the questionnaire across Bangladesh, including social media and personal networks. Participation was voluntary and anonymous, and eligibility was restricted to adults aged 18 years and over. Eligibility was restricted to adults aged 18 and over, enforced through numeric validation on the age field. Collection ran from 4 to 20 September 2026 and produced 202 responses, of which 183 remained after screening. Participants averaged 23.0 years of age (SD = 3.8) and reported 5.76 hours of daily social media use (SD = 3.00); 93 were women and 89 men. An a priori power analysis put the requirement at 64 participants per condition to detect a medium effect at 80% power with $\alpha = .05$. The final sample gave 117 participants in the human condition and 66 in the AI condition.

B. Stimulus and Manipulation

The post was written for this study. It argues against buying a skincare serum on grounds of price, ingredient concentration and product stability, then points the reader toward a cheaper alternative, following the argument structure described in earlier de-influencing research [2], [3]. We invented the brand rather than naming a real one. A real product would have dragged prior familiarity into the design, and responses would then have carried whatever participants already believed about that brand alongside their reaction to the message.

Everything that differed between conditions sat in one line above the post, saying either that a human content creator had written it or that an AI tool had generated it. We put it there because that is where platform disclosure notices appear.

Assignment ran inside the questionnaire, using an attribute unrelated to anything the study measures. Participants stated which half of the calendar year their birthday falls in, and the form branched from there. Its purpose was not disclosed. Because this is quasi-random rather than strictly random assignment, we checked the two groups against each other on every demographic variable before turning to the main analyses.

C. Measures

Ten constructs were measured, each with three items on a five-point Likert scale running from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). We adapted items from published instruments so that the constructs stay comparable with earlier work and can be tested for internal consistency. Perceived expertise and source credibility come from Ohanian [10], perceived authenticity from de-influencing research [3], perceived transparency from work on virtual influencers [8], and message persuasiveness from research on negative reviews [5]. Dispositional skepticism follows Obermiller and Spangenberg [12], and AI literacy draws on recent consumer-facing AI research [6], [7]. The outcome measures adapt trust items from influencer marketing [1] and anti-consumption behaviours from de-influencing research [2], [3]. We also recorded age, gender, education, occupation, daily social media hours and weekly exposure to de-influencing content.

Consumer trust was taken as the mean of its three items and rescaled to a 0–100 range. Anti-consumption was computed the same way and then split at 3.0, the neutral midpoint of the scale, so that a positive classification means the participant actually agreed rather than merely scoring above whatever the sample median happened to be. A manipulation check asked participants to identify the source of the post immediately after reading it.

D. Procedure and Ethics

Consent came before any question appeared, and anyone declining went straight to the end of the form. Nothing identifying was collected. We disabled email collection and the single-response restriction, since both require participants to sign in and would have broken the anonymity the consent text promised. Participation was voluntary and could be abandoned at any point.

Since participants in one condition received a source label that did not describe where the post actually came from, a debriefing statement appeared on submission. It explained that the post had been written for the study, that the brand was fictional, and that participants had seen one of two source labels so the responses could be compared.

E. Data Screening

Screening rules were fixed before the data were examined. A response was removed if consent was declined, if any measurement item was missing, if every Likert item carried the same answer, or if the participant reported zero hours of daily social media use. Of 202 responses received, 3 declined consent and 16 were straight-line responses, leaving 183 valid cases.

Two instructional attention checks had been embedded within the Likert grids, and both were abandoned as screening criteria once the data were inspected. Pass rates were 21.3% and 31.1%, close to what random responding would produce on a five-point scale. Three observations indicate that the items failed rather than the participants. The response distributions on both checks were centred rather than flat, with means of 3.43 and 3.74 against the 3.0 that random responding would give. Internal consistency across the ten constructs ran from $\alpha = .713$ to $\alpha = .840$, which inattentive responding cannot produce. And the grid columns presented the options as bare numerals, with the verbal anchors given once above the grid, so a row reading “please pick 2 for this line” was formatted exactly like the agreement statements around it. Participants appear to have processed the instruction as one more statement to agree or disagree with. Excluding on this basis would have removed four-fifths of an otherwise attentive sample, so the checks are reported as a measurement limitation instead.

F. Analysis

Internal consistency was assessed with Cronbach’s alpha against a threshold of .70. Every variable derives from one self-report instrument, so Harman’s single-factor test for common method bias was also run [13], returning 47.3% of variance on the first factor. A binomial test compared the manipulation check pass rate against chance. Welch’s t-test compared consumer trust across conditions, both in the full sample and within the subgroup that passed the manipulation check, and a chi-square test examined the association between condition and anti-consumption.

Twelve predictors entered the models: the seven construct composites, content type, and controls for age, gender, daily social media hours and weekly exposure frequency, giving 15.2 observations per predictor. Individual measurement items were kept out, since entering them would have pushed the predictor count toward the number of observations. Variance inflation factors ran from 1.06 to 4.14. Four regression and five classification algorithms were evaluated on an 80:20 stratified split with five-fold cross-validation. We report cross-validated metrics as the primary basis for comparison and treat the holdout results as confirmation, because a test set of 37 cases yields accuracy estimates that move noticeably depending on how the split falls.

IV. Results

A. Sample and Measurement Quality

The final sample comprised 183 valid responses, 117 in the human condition and 66 in the AI condition. The groups did not differ on age ($p = .625$), gender ($p = .260$), education ($p = .814$), occupation ($p = .057$) or weekly exposure to de-influencing content ($p = .663$). Daily social media use differed modestly ($p = .031$) and is retained as a covariate in all models. The uneven group sizes follow from the assignment procedure described in Section III-B.

All ten constructs met the conventional reliability threshold, as Table II shows. Harman’s test returned 47.3% of variance on the first factor, below the 50% criterion, though the first eigenvalue of 14.20 against 1.77 for the second, together with a mean inter-construct correlation of .655, indicates substantial shared method variance. Section VI takes this up.

TABLE II. Descriptive Statistics and Reliability

Construct (3 items each)	M	SD	α
Perceived authenticity	3.30	1.03	.788
Perceived expertise	3.36	0.95	.739
Perceived transparency	3.23	0.92	.713
Message persuasiveness	3.32	0.94	.765
Source credibility	3.17	1.07	.840
Dispositional skepticism	3.48	0.95	.744
AI literacy	3.42	0.94	.770
Consumer trust	3.45	0.97	.796
Anti-consumption	3.44	0.94	.740
Negative word-of-mouth	3.43	1.00	.776

B. Perception of the Source Label (H1)

Immediately after reading the post, participants were asked who had created it. Of 183 participants, 93 answered correctly, a rate of 50.8%. A binomial test against chance was not significant ($p = .883$, 95% CI [.433, .583]). Accuracy was 48.7% in the human condition and 54.5% in the AI condition. H1 was not supported. Participants were no better than chance

at reporting a source label they had seen seconds earlier, even though the label was the heading directly above the post.

Its wording was also unambiguous, stating either that a human content creator had written the post or that an AI tool had generated it.

C. Attributed Source and Trust (H2)

In the full sample, consumer trust averaged 60.40 (SD = 24.10) in the human condition and 62.50 (SD = 24.56) in the AI condition. The difference was not significant, $t(132.8) = -0.56$, $p = .577$, $d = -0.09$, 95% CI [−9.53, 5.33]. The chi-square test of condition against anti-consumption behavior was likewise not significant, $\chi^2(1) = 0.21$, $p = .644$, with 59.0% of the human group and 63.6% of the AI group classified as showing anti-consumption. Fig. 1 shows the distribution of consumer trust in each condition.

Restricting the analysis to the 93 participants who passed the manipulation check produced a larger difference, running opposite to the intuitive prediction. Trust averaged 59.06 (SD = 25.94) in the human condition and 67.82 (SD = 20.13) in the AI condition, $t(87.1) = -1.82$, $p = .072$, $d = -0.37$, 95% CI [−18.31, 0.79]. The difference falls short of conventional significance in a subgroup of this size, but its direction is consistent: among participants who registered the label, AI attribution went with higher trust. H2 is not supported in the full sample and remains open within the subgroup.

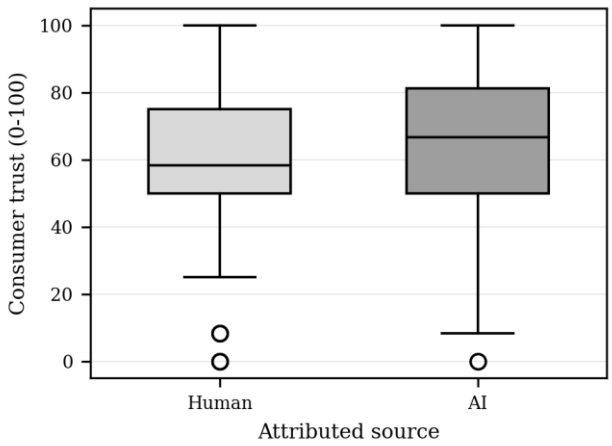


Fig. 1. Consumer trust by attributed source, full sample.

D. Predictors of Consumer Trust (H3, H4)

All five perceptual constructs correlated positively and significantly with consumer trust: message persuasiveness ($r = .717$), perceived transparency ($r = .709$), perceived authenticity ($r = .680$), perceived expertise ($r = .679$) and source credibility ($r = .569$), all $p < .001$. H3 was supported. Consumer trust correlated with anti-consumption behavior at $r = .657$, $p < .001$, supporting H4. Dispositional skepticism also correlated positively with trust ($r = .687$), which runs against theoretical expectation; Section VI addresses it.

E. Predictive Modelling

Table III reports regression performance for consumer trust and Table IV reports classification performance for anti-consumption behavior. Ridge regression achieved the highest cross-validated R^2 at .578, and logistic regression and random forest tied on cross-validated AUC at .879.

TABLE III. REGRESSION PERFORMANCE: CONSUMER TRUST

Model	CV R^2	SD	Test R^2	RMSE	MAE
Ridge Regression	.578	.041	.655	15.86	13.24
Linear Regression	.576	.041	.655	15.87	13.24
Random Forest	.570	.085	.688	15.08	12.45
SVR	.539	.041	.609	16.90	13.62

TABLE IV. CLASSIFICATION PERFORMANCE: ANTI-CONSUMPTION

Model	CV AUC	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	Spec.	F1
Logistic Regression	.879	.892	.875	.955	.800	.913
Random Forest	.879	.892	.875	.955	.800	.913
k-NN	.828	.838	.833	.909	.733	.870
SVM	.819	.811	.800	.909	.667	.851
Decision Tree	.804	.865	.870	.909	.800	.889

F. Relative Importance of Attributed Source

Random Forest feature importance placed message persuasiveness first (.250), then AI literacy (.192), perceived authenticity (.147) and dispositional skepticism (.139). Attributed source came last of the twelve predictors at .004, as Fig. 2 shows. The experimental manipulation contributed less to the prediction of consumer trust than participant gender (.006) or age (.035).

Because attributed source was assigned by the experiment rather than reported by participants, its position cannot be an artefact of response style, and whatever inflates the correlations among the self-reported measures does not touch it.

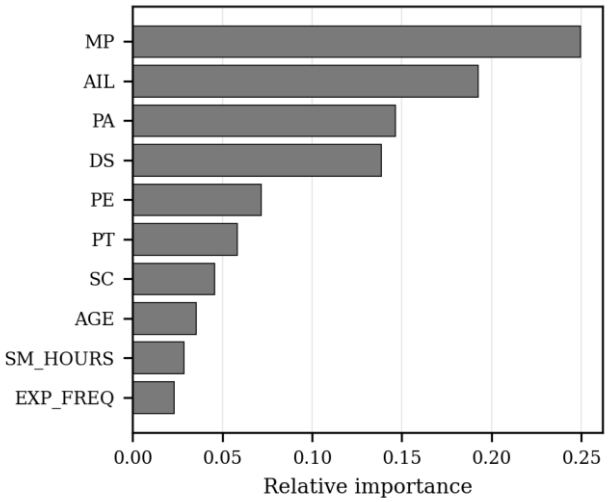


Fig. 2. Random Forest feature importance for consumer trust.

V. DISCUSSION

Half of our participants could not say who had written a post they had finished reading moments before. The label was short, unambiguous, and sat directly above the content. The proportion reporting it correctly did not differ from what guessing would produce.

The policy conversation around AI disclosure has mostly started one step further along. The usual question is whether disclosure reduces trust, or whether it should, or by how much, and that question assumes a reader who has taken the disclosure in and is deciding what to do with it. Our participants, reading in conditions closer to a social feed than to a laboratory, mostly never got that far. Where labels take this position and this form, the practical difficulty is that a substantial share of readers never encounter the information at all.

The finding also bears on how source-labelling experiments should be read. Jakesch et al. found that AI attribution reduced trust only when participants could compare

labelled and unlabelled profiles, and read this comparatively [9]. Our data suggest a second mechanism worth considering. A mixed set forces attention onto the label, because the label is what varies across the items being compared, while a uniform set gives the reader no particular reason to attend to it. Some of what looks like comparative suspicion may be comparative attention.

Among the minority who did register the label, trust was higher in the AI condition, with a moderate effect that did not reach significance in a subgroup of 93. The direction is worth reporting because it is counterintuitive, and it fits the reasoning that led us to state H2 without a predicted direction. One reading is that a machine has no commercial interest to hide. The suspicion an audience brings to a human creator advising against a purchase, that some rival sponsorship lies behind the advice, does not attach to an AI system in the same way. We put this forward as a hypothesis for a study designed to test it, not as a conclusion from a marginal subgroup result.

The modelling results point in the same direction. Across twelve predictors, attributed source ranked last, contributing .004 to a model that explained a cross-validated 57.8% of the variance in consumer trust. What predicted trust was the perceived quality of the message: how convincing the argument seemed, how authentic the creator appeared. For creators, the substance of a de-influencing argument appears to matter considerably more than the method of production. For platforms, a disclosure label placed where ours was will change very little, and the design question becomes how to disclose in a form readers actually perceive.

VI. Limitations and Conclusion

The most serious limitation is shared method variance. All constructs were measured through one self-report instrument. Harman's test returned 47.3% on the first factor, marginally below the conventional criterion, but the first eigenvalue of 14.20 against 1.77 for the second, along with a mean inter-construct correlation of .655, indicates a strong general factor. Dispositional skepticism correlated positively with consumer trust at $r = .687$, the opposite of what theory predicts, which is most plausibly an acquiescence effect. The instrument contained no reverse-coded items, a decision taken to keep the wording unambiguous for participants who are not first-language English speakers, and their absence left no way to detect or correct this response style. The correlational and regression results should be read accordingly. The experimental comparison is unaffected, since attributed source was assigned rather than reported.

The instructional attention checks failed as instruments for the reasons given in Section III-E, leaving the sample less thoroughly screened than intended. Assignment was quasi-random and produced uneven group sizes. The sample was drawn by convenience from a single country and skews toward students, so it supports comparison between assigned conditions rather than population estimates. Behavioral intention was measured rather than behavior. A single stimulus in a single product category was used, and a label placed elsewhere, or rendered more prominently, might well be perceived at a higher rate; what we report applies to the standard position, not to disclosure in general.

We set out to compare consumer responses to identical de-influencing content attributed to a human creator and to an AI tool, and found that the attribution largely went unread. Only 50.8% of participants could identify the source of a post they had just finished, a rate indistinguishable from chance. Consumer trust did not differ between conditions, and across twelve predictors the attributed source ranked last, well behind the perceived persuasiveness and authenticity of the message. Machine learning models predicted trust with a cross-validated R^2 of .578 and anti-consumption behavior with a cross-validated AUC of .879, in both cases on the strength of perceptual factors, with provenance adding almost nothing. Future work should test label placement and salience directly, because before disclosure policy can ask how readers weigh AI authorship, it needs to know whether they notice it.

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